

LBO Case Competition

UConn School of Business

LBO Case Competition Fall 2026 Kickoff

September 18, 2026

Noon–1:30 p.m. ET on Zoom

Competition Kickoff



Your Team Develops an Investment Recommendation

Choose a public company and assess whether it would make a compelling leveraged buyout.

Understand the Business

Research how it earns money, what makes it competitive and where it could improve.

Test the Economics

Model the purchase, financing, cash flow and potential return under realistic assumptions.

Defend the Decision

Explain your recommendation in the Flash Memo and presentation, including the risks.

What Happens in a Leveraged Buyout?

A financial sponsor buys a company using equity and debt, then aims to sell the investment at a profit.

At Acquisition

The purchase price and funding determine how much equity the sponsor invests.

During Ownership

Business performance and cash generation support investment and debt repayment.

At Exit

The sale value, cash and remaining debt determine the equity proceeds and sponsor return.

The Build Guide explains the concepts in more detail, including what makes a promising LBO target.

Competition Schedule

Date	Milestone	What to Expect
September 18	Kickoff on Zoom	Noon–1:30 p.m. ET
September 22	Mentor Introductions	By email
October 2	Proposed Company Name	Initial fit check
October 23	Flash Memo	Three core slides + optional fourth
November 6	Semifinal on Zoom	9:30 a.m.–3:30 p.m. ET
November 9	Final Four Announcement	Four teams advance
November 13	Final in New York City	All participants expected

Submission instructions and final-event logistics will follow. Mentor meetings are arranged separately around mentor availability.

Four Resources with Different Roles

Build Guide (PDF)	A reference for understanding LBOs and thinking through the investment case.
LBO Model (Excel)	The Excel model and Read Me First guidance. This is where your assumptions become cash flows and returns.
Flash Memo (PowerPoint)	An editable summary of your analysis. Read the slide notes for guidance on each section.
Kickoff Slides (PDF)	Today's orientation, competition milestones and mentor expectations. Shared after the kickoff.

The examples are starting points. Your team supplies the company research and investment judgment.

Evaluating a Strong LBO Candidate

Business and Price

Look for understandable demand, a defensible competitive position and cash flow after necessary investment.

Consider credible improvements and a purchase price that leaves room for a return.

Competition Boundaries

Choose a public company with \$500 million–\$10 billion in enterprise value. Check the Build Guide's sector and prior-target exclusions.

October 2 asks for the company name for a fit check. You do not need a completed model at that point.

The Build Guide includes the financing guardrails and questions to help you assess whether the target can support debt.

Library Resources and Consensus Estimates

S&P Capital IQ can help you find candidates, understand financial performance and compare your forecast with analyst expectations.

Start with Library Resources

Capital IQ: public-company financials, peers and analyst estimates.

PitchBook and Preqin Pro: supporting research on deals, sponsors and private markets.

S&P Global

PitchBook
a Morningstar company

PREQIN
a part of BlackRock

[Library Links and Access Help: \[ibocompetition.com/resources\]\(https://ibocompetition.com/resources\)](https://ibocompetition.com/resources)

The Build Guide explains the Capital IQ workflow and how to interpret consensus estimates.

Use Estimates Thoughtfully

Consensus summarizes analysts' forecasts. Compare it with company guidance and your own reasoning about growth and profitability.

The range of views can help you test assumptions and develop a downside case.

Your Mentor Brings a Professional Perspective

Each team will be introduced to a mentor who is volunteering time and experience to support your work.

What Mentors Contribute

Advice on the business, feedback on your reasoning and questions that challenge your assumptions.

This is an opportunity to learn how an experienced professional evaluates an investment.

What Your Team Contributes

Students lead the research, analysis and preparation. Come with a view to discuss and questions that would benefit from your mentor's perspective.

Your preparation and follow-through help make the experience valuable for everyone.

Starting the Mentor Relationship

After the Introduction

Promptly send a clear team introduction, thank your mentor and ask about availability and preferred ways to communicate.

Planning Meetings

Work around your mentor's schedule. Agree on a rhythm that works for them, usually weekly or every other week.

Professional Communication

Write carefully, make requests clear and give enough context for a useful response. Coordinate as a team so your mentor receives a coherent message.

A mentor's time is a contribution to your learning. Treat the relationship with care throughout the competition.

Preparation Makes Meetings More Useful

Before

Share a short agenda, relevant work and focused questions. Give your mentor time to review what you send.

During

Explain your reasoning, listen carefully and ask follow-up questions. Be open to a challenge to your assumptions.

After

Thank your mentor and follow through on agreed actions. Show how the feedback helped your analysis, including where your judgment differs.

If communication or scheduling becomes difficult, contact Professor Ghaddar early.

First Look at the Model

Read Me First

Understand the purpose of the model, input conventions and which assumptions are supplied.

Assumptions and Structure

Locate the entry assumptions, funding and operating forecast. Notice how they connect to cash flow and debt.

Results and Review

Find sponsor returns and the model checks. A correct formula does not establish a credible investment assumption.

Today's walkthrough is an introduction. Use Read Me First and the Build Guide when you begin your own analysis.

Summarizing Your Case

Slide 1	Company overview, financial summary, investment thesis and transaction rationale.
Slide 2	Business segments, major customers and geographic revenue.
Slide 3	Short Form LBO Analysis, including financing assumptions and returns.
Optional Slide 4	Technology and value creation: a relevant opportunity to improve the business, supported by evidence.

Due October 23. The optional component can be discussed without changing the model. Keep all financial figures consistent.

From the Semifinal to New York City

November 6 Semifinal

Zoom, 9:30 a.m.–3:30 p.m. ET.

Each team joins for one assigned 30-minute slot, including discussion. Prepare 8–10 slides.

The Final Four announcement follows on November 9.

November 13 Final

The final takes place in New York City. All participants are expected to attend, including students whose teams do not advance.

Final-event logistics will be shared separately.

Your First Steps after the Kickoff

Get Organized

Agree on how your team will communicate, share research and review one another's work.

Explore the Packet

Start with the model's Read Me First tab, review the Build Guide and explore the Flash Memo template and its notes.

Build a Shortlist

Research eligible companies before investing heavily in a single model.

Connect with Your Mentor

After the email introduction, reach out thoughtfully and arrange your first conversation.

The first submission is the proposed company name on October 2. Bring questions and early concerns to Professor Ghaddar.